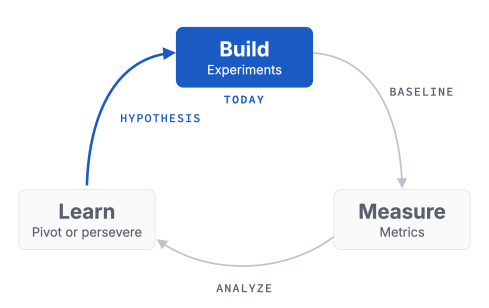
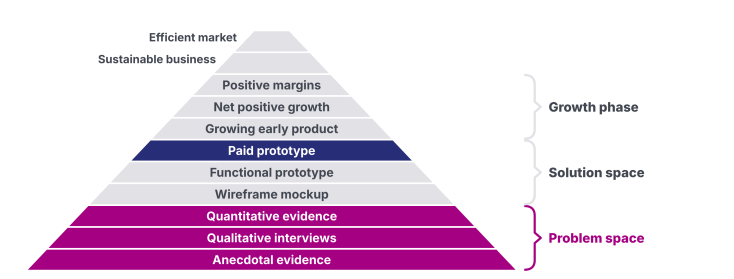
Workshop 00: Startup Autopsy

Updated: 2026-10-19.

MODULE 00 · KICKOFF · WORKSHOP · GOALS M00-LG1 TO LG4



Today you start the loop. You close it this week.



You start at the bottom. It's a signal until somebody pays.

Today starts your week of problem conversations. You leave with the first messages to real people already sent. The examples below are made up.

The 90 minutes

Time	Step	You leave with
25′	1 · Autopsy your own startup	Your riskiest untested assumption, logged
25′	2 · Write hypotheses you can lose	3 ranked hypotheses, their evidence, a kill line
40′	3 · Reach real people, then commit	Messages sent, target, pace, possible teammates

Step 1 · Autopsy your own startup (25′)

Goal. Find the customer assumption most likely to kill your idea.

1. **Write your starting point** in one line.
2. **Kill it.** It's one year from now and your startup is dead. Write down why, alone, in 5 minutes.
3. **Turn each cause into a belief.** "We assumed [who] has [problem] and pays to fix it."
4. **Circle the one** that kills you if it's wrong and that nobody has tested.
5. **Defend it in pairs.** Your partner asks "How do you know?" until you hit an opinion.
6. **Log it** in the Toolkit's Weekly Reflection.

Good	Weak
"We assumed lab managers in biotech start-ups lose hours on reagent orders and would pay to stop."	"We assumed the tech works."

Output. Your riskiest untested assumption, logged.

Step 2 · Write hypotheses you can lose (25′)

Goal. Turn that assumption into problem hypotheses a stranger could prove wrong this week.

1. **Write 3** in the Experiment Tracker. “[Who] struggles with [problem] when [situation]. Today they [workaround], which costs them [hours or euros].”
2. **Rate the evidence** behind each. Opinion, anecdote, conversation or payment? Only a payment is proof.
3. **Rank them,** riskiest first. Start AI deep research on where your “who” talks.
4. **Log a kill line** in the Kill Criteria Log before you talk to anyone. The homework has one ready.

Good	Weak
“Lab managers in biotech start-ups struggle to track reagent orders when several teams order at once. Today they keep an Excel sheet, which costs them about 4 hours a week.”	“Scientists need an AI lab assistant.” A solution, a vague who, no cost.

Output. 3 ranked hypotheses, their evidence, a kill line.

Step 3 · Reach real people, then commit (40′)

Goal. Leave with the week already moving.

1. **Find (10′).** Pick named people, not personas. Try people you see every day, product reviewers and your research.
2. **Reach out (15′).** Ask for a short talk about their work. Don’t name your problem, and do NOT pitch. Send 5 messages, or call one now. Friends, family and classmates don’t count. Their intros do.
3. **Commit (10′).** Copy the bar. “Write 3 problem hypotheses and hold 15 problem conversations with named people, learning what the problem costs each of them today, and come back with 3 people who agreed to a next step. The learning floor is 3 hypotheses and 5 conversations with 1 next step.” Pick floor or full bar and a midweek day. 15 a week is 3 a day.
4. **Find teammates (5′).** Tell the room your problem space in one sentence and note who shares it. Teams commit in Module 01. Nobody found? We match you.

Good	Weak
“Hi Anna, I’m talking to lab managers about how their week runs. Could I ask you about yours, 15 minutes?”	“Hi, I’m building an AI tool for lab orders. Would you use it?”

Output. Messages sent, target, pace, possible teammates.

Arrived empty-handed?

No idea, no technology, no team? You’re right on time. Run the autopsy on a frustration you watched someone fight last month, at work or in your lab.

Bring and use

The Validation Hierarchy, the Mom Test Cheatsheet and the Student Toolkit. The lecture and the case are background.